WhatsApp and Viber scams across JAPAC

Sixteen patterns cover almost everything ordinary adults meet when the ask arrives on WhatsApp or Viber. Rank is how often people see it. A live game draws four of these at random. The seeded video chat is Friend or family in trouble.

Singapore figures are from the Singapore Police Force Mid-Year Scam and Cybercrime Brief, 26 August 2026. India follows Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre advisories and the 2026 digital-arrest enforcement report. Australia follows Scamwatch. Where a public advisory does not cleanly count the WhatsApp or Viber split, the country is marked low confidence.

The 16 most common

1. Friend or family in trouble

Both ages. Major in Singapore, India, Australia, Hong Kong, Indonesia, and the Philippines.

A known contact, or someone on a new number claiming to be them, needs money for a broken phone, a locked bank app, or a hospital bill, and asks you to pay before you reach the real person. The transfer goes to a stranger. Often their chat was taken over first, so the same story then hits their other friends. Signals: a new number, urgency, a request not to call, an account you have never paid.

2. Paid-task job

Mostly working-age. Major across Singapore, Malaysia, Indonesia, the Philippines, India, Hong Kong, and Australia.

A stranger offers home-based work liking posts or clearing tiny tasks. The first payout is small and real, then you must pay to unlock the next task or to withdraw. The deposits are gone. Some chats later ask you to receive and forward other people's money, which leaves your name on the account the bank sees. Signals: no interview, high pay for almost no work, a group of profit screenshots, any pay-to-get-paid step.

3. Investment mentor or trading group

Both ages, with the largest losses among older adults. Major in Singapore, Hong Kong, Malaysia, Australia, and India.

A wrong-number chat, a dating chat, or an ad becomes a mentor and a group. Tips seem to win. You are moved onto a site that shows rising profit, then told to deposit more. Withdrawal is blocked by a fee or a tax. The on-screen balance was never real. Singapore Police recorded about S$170 million lost to investment scams in the first half of 2026, the biggest loss of any type. A current variant is a WhatsApp learning group posing as a university or a broker. Signals: an unsolicited group, guaranteed returns, a new app, a fee to cash out, pressure to keep it secret.

4. Police, court, or digital arrest

Mostly older adults. Major in India, Singapore, Malaysia, and Hong Kong.

A call or chat ties a parcel, a bank account, or your identity to a crime. You are passed to someone posing as police or a court, kept on a video call, and told to move money to a safe account or hand cash to a courier. Savings move while the call stays open. In Singapore, phone and WhatsApp are the main channels for this type, and about 41 percent of those victims in the first half of 2026 were 65 or older. India's I4C tracks the same pattern as digital arrest on WhatsApp. Signals: a threat of arrest, a uniform on video, secrecy from family, any order to move your own money for safekeeping.

5. Code, QR, or rented account

Both ages. Major in India, Indonesia, Malaysia, the Philippines, and Singapore.

Someone needs a code that just arrived, a scan to link a device, or an install so you can earn by renting your account. They then control the chat and message your contacts. I4C has warned that linking WhatsApp for pay turns the account into a mule account. Signals: any one-time code, a linked-device QR, an app file in the chat, pay for the use of your own account.

6. Parcel fee or address problem

Both ages. Major in Indonesia, Malaysia, India, and the Philippines, and still common in Singapore and Australia.

A courier says a parcel is stuck and a small fee or a new address will release it. The link looks like the courier. The card or bank login is taken, and the card is sometimes added to a phone wallet. Signals: a parcel you were not expecting, a link, a small fee, a page that asks for a card and a code.

7. Bank, KYC, or wallet check

Both ages. Major in India, Indonesia, the Philippines, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, and Singapore.

The bank, the regulator, or the wallet will block the account unless you confirm a link, read a code, or update KYC in the chat. The account is emptied, or a loan is opened in your name. Signals: closure today, a link, a code, details that are only half right. The check belongs in the real bank app, opened by you.

8. Buyer or seller who leaves the listing

Mostly working-age. Major in the Philippines, Malaysia, Indonesia, India, Australia, and Hong Kong.

The price is far too good, or a buyer sends a payment picture and wants the item shipped, an overpayment refunded, or the deal finished on WhatsApp or Viber. The goods never come, or you ship and the payment is fake. Singapore's top scam by case count in the first half of 2026 was e-commerce. Signals: off-platform payment, a screenshot as proof, a price that ignores the local market.

9. Fast romance, then a bill

Both ages. Major in Australia, Malaysia, the Philippines, and India.

After a dating app or a wrong-number hello, the chat turns intimate quickly, then a crisis, a ticket, or a shared investment appears. Transfers repeat, and many of these become the investment scam. Signals: they will not meet, affection arrives on a schedule, the money story shows up after the bond.

10. Video, then a threat

Mostly working-age. Common in India, the Philippines, Malaysia, Indonesia, and Australia.

A flirt moves straight to video, then they threaten to send it to your contacts unless money moves now. The first payment is followed by another demand. Signals: speed, they already know your contacts, a deadline of minutes.

11. App or document in the chat

Both ages. Major in India and Indonesia, and seen in Singapore malware cases.

An invoice, a security tool, or a job app has to be installed from the chat. The app can read codes and banking screens, and money moves without a further story. Signals: install from the chat, a request for screen access, a familiar logo on an unfamiliar file.

12. Boss or supplier changes the payment

Mostly working-age. A business pattern in Singapore, Hong Kong, Australia, and Malaysia.

A boss, lawyer, or supplier says a deal is confidential and the account has changed, or asks for gift cards. Some add a video call with a faked face. The company payment goes to a mule account. In March 2025 a Singapore finance director sent about S$670,000 after a WhatsApp approach and a faked video meeting. Hong Kong police helped trace it. Signals: secrecy, a new account, gift cards, a path that skips the usual approval.

13. Prize that needs a fee

Both ages. Steady in India, the Philippines, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal, and Indonesia.

You won a draw you never entered, and a tax or fee has to be paid first. The fee is paid and the prize never arrives. Signals: a win without an entry, a fee before any payout, a request for an ID copy.

14. Loan fee or debt threat

Both ages. Major as harassment in Indonesia, and present in the Philippines, India, and Singapore.

A loan is approved if a fee is paid first, or a debt you do not owe will be sent to family, sometimes with photos from the phone. The fee is lost, or the shame is used to demand more. Signals: a fee before any money arrives, threats to message contacts, pressure to open your photos.

15. Overseas job that takes the passport

Mostly working-age. A top harm for the Philippines, Indonesia, India, Nepal, Bangladesh, and Myanmar.

High pay abroad is arranged entirely in chat, the ticket is rushed, and the employer cannot be called on any number you find yourself. On arrival the passport is taken and the person is held and put to work. The family is then asked to pay for release. The destination story often points at Cambodia, Laos, or Myanmar. Signals: the employer exists only in the chat, travel is immediate, secrecy from family, a destination you did not apply for.

16. Refund that is actually a payment

Both ages. Major in India, and present in Singapore and Malaysia.

A refund or a buyer payment is waiting if you scan a code. The code pays them. Signals: scanning in order to receive, an amount you did not type, a refund that cannot be done inside the official app.

Where people meet them

WhatsApp is a main channel in India, Indonesia, Singapore, Malaysia, Hong Kong, Australia, New Zealand, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Brunei, and Macau. Viber is a main channel in the Philippines, alongside WhatsApp, and in Myanmar. Fiji uses both. Papua New Guinea is mostly Facebook, with WhatsApp behind it.

Japan, South Korea, Taiwan, Thailand, and Vietnam still belong on the map, and WhatsApp or Viber is uncommon there. Everyday scams arrive on LINE, KakaoTalk, or Zalo. Cambodia and Laos are thin on these two apps. Their larger part in this catalog is as the destination in the overseas-job pattern.

India WhatsApp · High confidence
Digital arrest, KYC, task jobs, investment, account rental, parcel, sextortion

Indonesia WhatsApp · Medium confidence
Parcel, task jobs, account takeover, loan threats, bank impersonation

Singapore WhatsApp · High confidence
Task jobs, investment groups, government impersonation, hijacked friends, phishing

Malaysia WhatsApp · Medium confidence
Police and bank impersonation, task jobs, investment, romance, parcel

Philippines Viber and WhatsApp · Medium confidence
Task jobs, wallet phishing, parcel, romance, marketplace, overseas jobs

Hong Kong WhatsApp · High confidence
Investment, task jobs, shopping, payment diversion, friend impersonation

Australia WhatsApp · High confidence
Investment, task jobs, romance, hijacked family, marketplace

New Zealand WhatsApp · Medium confidence
Same mix as Australia, at lower volume

Bangladesh WhatsApp · Medium confidence
Task jobs, lottery, account takeover, bank impersonation, overseas jobs

Sri Lanka WhatsApp · Low confidence
Bank impersonation, lottery, task jobs, account takeover

Nepal WhatsApp · Low confidence
Overseas jobs, lottery, account takeover, impersonation

Myanmar Viber · Low confidence
Task jobs, investment, impersonation, overseas-job offers

Fiji Viber and WhatsApp · Low confidence
Romance, parcel, task jobs

Brunei WhatsApp · Low confidence
Malaysian mix, at a small scale

Macau WhatsApp · Low confidence
Investment, jobs, shopping, and impersonation, following Hong Kong

Papua New Guinea WhatsApp, behind Facebook · Low confidence
Marketplace and impersonation. Thin official detail

Japan Uncommon. LINE is the everyday app · Low confidence
Some foreign-resident and cross-border business chats

South Korea Uncommon. KakaoTalk is the everyday app · Low confidence
Local scam traffic sits on KakaoTalk

Taiwan Uncommon. LINE is the everyday app · Low confidence
Investment scams are common on LINE

Thailand Uncommon. LINE is the everyday app · Low confidence
Call-centre and LINE scams dominate

Vietnam Uncommon. Zalo is the everyday app · Low confidence
Local scam traffic sits on Zalo and Facebook

Cambodia Thin on these two apps · Low confidence
Larger story is job offers that move people into compounds

Laos Thin on these two apps · Low confidence
Same compound-job pattern as a destination

Also seen, outside the 16

Crypto-recovery fees after a loss, in Australia, New Zealand, Singapore, and Hong Kong. Rental deposits before a viewing, in Hong Kong, Singapore, Australia, and Malaysia. Pet or luxury-goods deposits, in Australia and New Zealand. Insurance-lapse threats, in Singapore, Malaysia, and India. Visa or recruitment fees, in Nepal, Bangladesh, the Philippines, India, and Sri Lanka. Remote-support installs, in Australia, New Zealand, and India. Disaster-charity spikes, and a code request after a SIM change, are uncommon.

How a card is used

Each card is one decisive moment. A slow scam gets a two-sentence setup, then the ask. A safe reply refuses, checks through a number or app the player already trusts, or reports. An unsafe reply pays, sends a code, opens the link, hands over access, or agrees to keep it secret. The usual ending above is what happens if they comply.

Sri Lanka, Nepal, Myanmar, Fiji, Brunei, Macau, Papua New Guinea, and the LINE, KakaoTalk, and Zalo countries are low confidence on the WhatsApp or Viber split. The pattern is right. The local volume is not something a public advisory currently counts cleanly.

Encounter patterns for a recognition game. WhatsApp and Viber only.

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